You said:

I need to research the monthly cost and availability of climate controlled storage units of multiple sizes across the United States. They must have 24/7 access, and the ability to receive packages on our behalf , it would be great if they would receive packages and place them in any unit we leased from them as well.

Worked for 31s

ChatGPT said:

Nationwide climate-controlled storage research

CESCo Depot Network | Preliminary market assessment | October 9, 2026

The initial research has identified a promising opportunity for CESCo's depot repair, inventory management, and preconfigured cold-spares business.

The most important finding is that several storage operators already provide more than rentable square footage. Some accept business deliveries, place packages inside leased units, and even retrieve inventory for customers. That means CESCo could establish geographically distributed stocking locations without initially operating staffed warehouses in every market.

The challenge is that **24/7 access, climate control, package acceptance, and unit placement are rarely guaranteed together at every facility.** We need to qualify individual properties rather than assume a national operator's standard services apply everywhere.

1. National storage costs by unit size

The following are published U.S. averages for climate-controlled units, based on January 2026 pricing data reported by SpareFoot using Yardi Matrix figures. They are useful as base-cost benchmarks, not actual quotes for fully serviced CESCo locations. SpareFoot

Unit size	Floor area	Average monthly rent	Cost per sq. ft./month
5 × 5 ft	25 sq. ft.	$53	$2.12
5 × 10 ft	50 sq. ft.	$82	$1.64
10 × 10 ft	100 sq. ft.	$134	$1.34
10 × 15 ft	150 sq. ft.	$179	$1.19
10 × 20 ft	200 sq. ft.	$232	$1.16
10 × 30 ft	300 sq. ft.	$327	$1.09

National climate-controlled monthly averages

Published January 2026 benchmarks, USD per month

Notice the economics: a 10 × 20 unit has eight times the floor area of a 5 × 5, but costs only about 4.4 times as much. Larger shared storage units could therefore be more profitable per allocated square foot, provided CESCo can maintain adequate utilization.

These averages do not include insurance, administrative fees, access upgrades, receiving charges, handling costs, or promotional-rate expirations.

2. Best operator candidates

Operator	Package acceptance	Placement inside unit	24/7 access
CubeSmart	Yes, select locations	Explicitly advertised	Verify individually
Extra Space Storage	Yes, select locations	Explicitly advertised	Select locations
StorageMart	Business service offered	Not yet verified	Select locations
Storage Post	Advertised	Not yet verified	Advertised for business storage
Public Storage	Most locations do not	Not established	Select locations

CubeSm... +5



1. CubeSmart — strongest service match

CubeSmart explicitly advertises package receipt, depositing deliveries inside customers' units, inventory retrieval, and preparation for pickup, delivery, or shipping. It also advertises a national-account program covering more than 1,250 facilities. These are unusually relevant capabilities for CESCo. Availability of the complete service bundle still requires property-level confirmation. CubeSmart

Business storage services ↗



2. Extra Space Storage — strong alternative

Extra Space says many facilities accept business deliveries and that some will bring packages into leased units. Some locations offer upgraded 24-hour access. It also has a national account program, though the published program specifically targets organizations requiring at least 25 units. Extra Sp... +2

Business storage services ↗



3. StorageMart — worthwhile regional candidate

StorageMart advertises commercial leasing arrangements that may include 24-hour access, on-site package acceptance, and access for multiple employees. Staff placement inside units needs confirmation. StorageMart

Explore facilities ↗

3. Actual advertised availability and pricing

I also found specific facilities advertising climate-controlled units, rather than relying exclusively on national averages.

Indianapolis — potential CESCo pilot



CubeSmart — 2135 North Illinois Street

2135 N Illinois St, Indianapolis, IN

Climate-controlled units in multiple sizes, with package acceptance explicitly listed on the property page. Publicly advertised units are reservable, but 24-hour access and staff placement inside the unit remain unverified. CubeSm... +1

View advertised units and pricing ↗

Size	Online monthly rate	Listed in-store rate
5 × 5	$12.00	$24
5 × 10	$24.50	$49
10 × 10	$36.50	$73
10 × 15	$45.50	$91
10 × 20	$74.50	$149

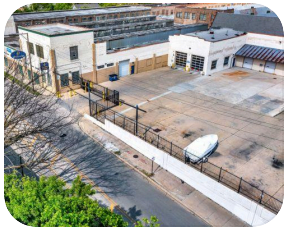
These are advertised online prices, not negotiated quotes or confirmed permanent rents. CubeSmart's site indicates promotional restrictions and additional fees can apply.

Another Indianapolis candidate is StorageMart at 1215 E Washington Street ↗, where advertised climate-controlled units include a 5 × 5 for $24 standard monthly rent with a $6 promotional rate, and a 5 × 10 for $34 standard with a $9 promotional rate. However, published entry hours begin at 6 AM, so it is not currently a verified 24/7-access solution. StorageMart

Chicago — useful second-market comparison

Storage Post — Belmont

2051 N Austin Avenue, Chicago, IL 60639



The property listing advertises climate-controlled storage and a 24-hour-access amenity. A separate access-hours section lists 6 AM–10 PM, however, so unrestricted access must be clarified before treating the property as eligible. Package acceptance is offered within Storage Post's business program, but needs property confirmation. Storage ... +2

View facility ↗

The Chicago listings include a climate-controlled 10 × 10 unit at $140/month and a ground-floor 10 × 20 unit at $289/month, before listed introductory discounts. These show how substantially geographic pricing can vary. Storage Post

Availability qualification: A unit appearing reservable online is evidence of advertised inventory, not a guarantee it will still be available when CESCo orders it. None of these example properties has yet been verified to satisfy all four mandatory requirements simultaneously.

One important correction to the Indianapolis candidate: CubeSmart's published access hours at 2135 N Illinois Street are **6 AM–10 PM daily**, not 24 hours. It therefore fails our strict access requirement unless management can provide a special arrangement. CubeSmart

4. How this could work for CESCo

For the depot platform, I would distinguish two service models:

Dedicated storage: A client leases a defined amount of space through CESCo, potentially backed by one separately controlled storage unit.

Shared storage: CESCo leases a larger unit and allocates shelving, bins, or pallet positions to several clients, subject to the storage provider permitting that arrangement.

Consider a hypothetical 10 × 20 climate-controlled facility costing $232 per month, based on the national average.

Shared-storage pricing sandbox

Illustrative CESCo pricing model — not a market quote

Monthly unit rent ($)

232

Other monthly costs ($)

75

Billable floor-space utilization	70%
Target markup over costs	40%

Required revenue / month	Price per billable sq. ft.
$429.80	$3.07
Total monthly costs	Projected contribution
$307.00	$122.80

Assumes all allocated billable space sells at the calculated rate. Excludes separately billed handling, taxes, and extraordinary losses. Markup is on cost, not profit margin.

For electronics, usable storage capacity should also consider cubic volume, shelving depth, clearances, aisle space, and weight limits. Floor-area pricing alone will not accurately describe the true capacity of every unit.

5. Requirements for a national storage partner

Before CESCo commits to any location, I would require written answers covering:

- **Access:** Genuine 24/7 physical access to the specific leased unit, including weekends and holidays—not merely 24-hour video surveillance.
- **Receiving:** FedEx, UPS, USPS, freight, pallets, oversized cartons, delivery frequency, and maximum weight.
- **Placement:** Whether staff will place deliveries inside our unit, what access authorization they require, and what this costs.
- **Chain of custody:** Package receipt timestamps, photographs, proof of delivery, discrepancies, and accountability for missing or damaged shipments.
- **Inventory retrieval:** Whether staff can pull a specified asset and release it to a courier or authorized field technician.
- **Commercial terms:** Regular rates, promotional expiration, future increases, insurance requirements, administrative fees, and multiple-unit discounts.
- **Permitted use:** Whether multiple CESCo clients' assets may occupy the same unit, and whether CESCo may charge customers for managed storage.
- **Security:** Employee access controls, key management, surveillance, fire protection, climate/humidity limits, and prohibited goods.

An important distinction: package acceptance during staffed office hours is not necessarily a problem even though **unit access must be available 24/7**. We should define those as separate service levels.

6. Proposed nationwide research scope

I would organize the national survey around major distribution markets rather than treating every city equally.

Region	Initial markets
Midwest	Indianapolis, Chicago, Columbus, Cincinnati, Detroit, St. Louis
Northeast	New York/New Jersey, Boston, Philadelphia, Pittsburgh
Southeast	Atlanta, Charlotte, Nashville, Orlando, Miami
South Central	Dallas–Fort Worth, Houston, Austin, San Antonio
West	Los Angeles, Phoenix, Las Vegas, Denver, Seattle, Portland, San Francisco Bay Area

For every qualifying property, the research database should record its actual available unit sizes, advertised and regular rents, climate controls, gate hours, delivery policies, unit-placement service, additional fees, and qualification date.

We should label facilities **Verified**, **Pending confirmation**, or **Disqualified**. At present, no specific facility has earned full Verified status.

7. Recommendation

I would approach CubeSmart and Extra Space Storage first, followed by StorageMart and Storage Post. Their business-storage programs create a reasonable starting point for CESCo to negotiate a standardized receiving and stocking arrangement across multiple cities.

There is also an important operational limit: having staff place an unopened package inside a unit does not mean CESCo has verified its serial number, inspected its condition, or updated its inventory. Those steps still require CESCo personnel or a contracted local technician. Our depot software should distinguish *received by facility*, *placed in storage*, and *verified into inventory*.

The next research milestone is a facility-level national rate and availability matrix. The findings above establish cost benchmarks, operator capabilities, and initial advertised inventory, but do not yet constitute a verified nationwide list meeting all CESCo requirements. That distinction matters before we build customer storage prices on these numbers.

The larger opportunity is to make physical storage a configurable service within CESCo Depot: one system for customer assets, multiple geographically distributed storage partners, and an auditable record of where every asset resides and who last handled it.

You said:

The three top operator candidates: cubesmart; extra space storage and storage mart -let's look at their locations nationally.

Worked for 23s

ChatGPT said:

CESCo Depot: National storage operator coverage

Market research | October 10, 2026

The three operators give us substantially different geographic footprints. Together, they offer a foundation for a distributed CESCo storage network, but their coverage is not equally broad.

1. Nationwide comparison

Approximate U.S. operating footprints

Extra Space	CubeSmart	StorageMart
4,300+	**1,500+**	**236–251**
42 states + DC	About 40 states + DC	22–24 states

Relative size of U.S. facility networks

Approximate operating footprint; StorageMart data from third-party location counts

Counts are not identical-date measurements. Extra Space and CubeSmart figures reflect company disclosures; StorageMart reflects third-party 2026 counts. Extra Sp... +3

From a geographic standpoint, **Extra Space Storage is the strongest national backbone**. CubeSmart is a valuable second operator, particularly because of its business receiving and inventory-handling services. StorageMart is smaller but offers useful regional concentration, especially in the Midwest.

Their location directories are available here:

- Extra Space Storage — U.S. facility directory ↗
- CubeSmart — national facility directory ↗

- StorageMart — U.S. city and facility directory ↗

2. Geographic concentrations

Here is where the operators' networks are most concentrated.

State	Extra Space	CubeSmart	StorageMart
Texas	607	98*	9
Florida	574	95*	14
California	432	63*	Present
New York	201	61*	Present
Illinois	177	47*	21
New Jersey	213	30*	Present
Arizona	156	51*	—
Georgia	217	Present	Present
Indiana	128	Present	9
Missouri	67	Present	45

Iowa	2	Present	29
Kansas	6	Present	19
Nebraska	9	No listed presence	15
Wisconsin	29	Present	14

*CubeSmart numbers are owned-property counts from December 31, 2025—not its entire managed network. “Present” means an operator lists facilities in the state; it is not a facility count. Extra Space counts are from an October 8, 2026 third-party locator inventory, and StorageMart figures from August 2026. SEC +4

What this tells us

Texas, Florida, California and the Northeast: Extra Space provides the greatest number of candidate facilities, with CubeSmart offering meaningful alternatives.

Midwest: StorageMart becomes much more interesting. Its concentration in Missouri, Iowa, Kansas, Nebraska, Wisconsin, and Illinois could support a regional CESCo network.

Indianapolis: All three operators have a presence, making it a practical pilot market before negotiating a larger national arrangement.

3. StorageMart's nationwide locations

StorageMart's official U.S. directory identifies properties across the following states and representative markets. This is the operator for which we can most readily identify a relatively manageable set of regional facilities.

Midwest and Central U.S.

Indiana (Indianapolis, Carmel, Fishers, Greenwood, Noblesville, Merrillville); Illinois (Chicago metropolitan area); Iowa (Des Moines metropolitan area, Davenport, Council Bluffs); Missouri (Kansas City, Columbia, Springfield); Kansas (Overland Park, Olathe, Lenexa); Nebraska (Omaha, Lincoln); Minnesota (Minneapolis metropolitan area); Wisconsin (Milwaukee metropolitan area).

Eastern and Southern U.S.

Florida (Miami, Fort Lauderdale, Fort Myers, Melbourne); Georgia (Athens, Canton, Lawrenceville, Milledgeville); Maryland (Baltimore area); New Jersey (Toms River, Trenton area); New York (Brooklyn, Manhattan and Queens); Texas (San Antonio, Austin); Kentucky (Lexington, Frankfort); Louisiana (Lake Charles); Pennsylvania (Philadelphia area); Virginia (Fairfax, Fredericksburg, Virginia Beach).

Western U.S.

California (Oakland, Concord, Fairfield, Morgan Hill, Santa Cruz area); Colorado (Vail valley); Idaho (Boise metropolitan area); Washington (Spokane).

Representative markets from StorageMart's official directory, not an exhaustive listing of street addresses.
StorageMart

An interesting data-quality issue emerged: StorageMart's own directory includes New York locations, while one third-party dataset reports no New York stores. Its September 2026 third-party count is also higher than the August estimate. For CESCo, I would use the live operator directory as the primary source and treat commercial datasets as secondary checks. Storage... +2

4. Priority metropolitan markets for CESCo

Rather than randomly selecting units nationwide, I propose investigating cities where we could support multiple client operations from a single storage location.

Priority	Metropolitan market	Operators to investigate
1	Indianapolis	All three
1	Chicago	All three
1	Dallas–Fort Worth	Extra Space, CubeSmart
1	Houston	Extra Space, CubeSmart
1	Atlanta	All three; check StorageMart proximity
1	New York / New Jersey	All three

2	Miami / South Florida	All three
2	Kansas City	StorageMart, Extra Space, CubeSmart
2	Columbus / Cincinnati	Extra Space, CubeSmart
2	Phoenix	Extra Space, CubeSmart
2	Los Angeles	Extra Space, CubeSmart
2	San Antonio	All three
3	Omaha	StorageMart, Extra Space
3	Des Moines	StorageMart, Extra Space, CubeSmart
3	Minneapolis	All three
3	Seattle	Extra Space, CubeSmart

These are **investigation priorities**, not verified facility-service matches. Each proposed metro requires actual facility screening.

5. Implications for choosing a national partner



Extra Space Storage

Best candidate for broad geographic coverage. Over 4,300 facilities and especially strong coverage in major population centers. Its facility network makes it a logical first choice for cities where CESCo needs to place cold spares close to client sites. Extra Space ...



CubeSmart

Best candidate to investigate for managed receiving and inventory logistics. Despite having fewer facilities, its business-service offerings may make particular locations substantially more useful than an ordinary self-storage property.



StorageMart

Particularly attractive for a Midwest-centered rollout. Its dense regional clusters might offer an opportunity for negotiating multi-location commercial arrangements.

6. The next level of research

What we have now is a national footprint assessment. What CESCo really needs is a **facility qualification database**, with every candidate location eventually carrying the following information:

Field	Research requirement
Location	Operator, address, city, state, ZIP
Unit inventory	5×5, 5×10, 10×10, 10×15, 10×20, larger
Climate control	Available and suitable for electronics
Access	True 24/7 access, including holidays
Deliveries	Packages accepted on CESCo's behalf
Placement	Staff can place deliveries inside our unit
Retrieval	Staff can retrieve assets for couriers
Cost	Advertised rent, regular rent, and service fees
Eligibility	Qualified, pending, or disqualified

A facility that accepts packages but closes access at 10 PM is not an equivalent substitute for one that offers every required service.

My recommendation is to establish two parallel tracks: examine CubeSmart for the most complete receiving-and-handling arrangement, while examining Extra Space for nationwide geographic coverage. Keep StorageMart as a potential regional partner, especially around Indianapolis and throughout the Midwest.

One particularly valuable question for corporate sales at all three operators is whether CESCo can establish a master commercial agreement allowing us to add locations as customer demand develops, with standardized receiving, access, and pricing terms.

That could turn an otherwise fragmented set of storage-unit rentals into a coordinated national physical infrastructure for CESCo Depot.

You said:

> I like your output. It's a good start I am stalled at examining operations right now because I think that what depot needs is the ability to present "space" to a client/prospective client AND we need to be able to reliably and consistently sell it on demand, we are selling something we don'

ChatGPT said:

I think you're identifying a fundamental issue in CESCo Depot's business model: **How do we reliably sell storage capacity that CESCo does not own, does not necessarily control, and may not even have reserved when a customer requests it?**

And I agree that this deserves attention before we go much further into the operations interface.

We are not simply building an inventory management system. We are building a platform that must connect three different things:

1. **Physical supply:** Storage capacity available from CubeSmart, Extra Space, StorageMart, or other providers.
2. **Commercial capacity:** Space CESCo can actually promise, price, and sell under an enforceable arrangement.
3. **Customer allocation:** Space assigned to a client's assets, with location, capacity, costs, and service commitments recorded.

Those three things are not interchangeable.

The distinction between advertised and sellable space

Consider a hypothetical 10 × 20 climate-controlled unit in Chicago.

The storage operator advertises it at $232/month. CESCo displays an equivalent storage offering to a customer. The customer accepts our price.

But before CESCo can lease the unit, somebody else rents it.

We've just sold something we cannot deliver.

The solution, I believe, is to make **capacity availability a managed state within Depot**, rather than a static listing of storage sizes and prices.

Proposed capacity lifecycle

Market capacity

A provider advertises available space

↓

Qualified capacity

CESCo verifies access, receiving, climate, terms and availability

↓

Committed capacity

Capacity is leased, contractually guaranteed or held under a binding agreement

↓

Allocated capacity

A specified portion is assigned to a customer

Only committed, unallocated capacity should be offered for immediate purchase with a firm fulfillment promise. Qualified but uncommitted capacity can still be displayed as *available by quote*, subject to confirmation before the customer is charged or promised a location.

I see three ways we could sell storage

Model	What CESCo sells	Financial exposure
On-demand procurement	A storage service that we source after receiving an order	Low advance cost; availability risk
Preleased shared capacity	A portion of space CESCo already controls	Fixed rent even when empty
Contracted capacity	Space a provider agrees to make available under specified terms	Depends on the agreement

A fourth option is a hybrid: maintain a small amount of leased capacity in high-demand markets and procure additional space on demand elsewhere.

For CESCo's current financial position, I would be cautious about leasing units speculatively. Instead, we could initially sell **confirmed storage proposals**, converting them into active subscriptions only after the underlying capacity has been secured.

What this means for Depot's design

I would introduce a *Storage Capacity Registry* separate from the Asset Registry.

The capacity registry would track provider locations, unit dimensions, usable cubic volume, climate specifications, access arrangements, delivery capabilities, procurement status, lease costs, available capacity, and customer allocations.

The customer-facing interface could then present two distinct offerings:

Ready to deploy

Capacity secured

A location where CESCo already controls enough suitable space to accept the customer's assets.

Eligible for immediate commitment

Available by request

Subject to confirmation

A service area where CESCo has qualified providers but has not yet secured capacity.

Requires verification and a confirmed quote

This also allows the customer to select a geographic service area without necessarily choosing the third-party storage company. CESCo becomes the accountable service provider rather than merely reselling a particular storage unit.

There's another important distinction: **space is not the only thing we're selling.** We're selling custody, receiving, secure holding, inventory visibility, asset retrieval, and potentially dispatch. Storage is the physical substrate beneath those services.

I would avoid coupling the customer subscription directly to a third-party unit number. Instead, the customer purchases a defined allocation and service level, while Depot maintains an auditable mapping to the actual physical facility, unit, shelf, bin, or pallet position.

That makes it possible to relocate assets without terminating and recreating the commercial agreement, provided the relocation complies with the customer's contract.

The issue we ultimately need to solve is not merely whether CubeSmart or Extra Space has a vacant 10 × 10 unit today. It is whether **CESCo can make a repeatable, credible commercial promise to provide storage in that market tomorrow, next month, and next year.**

And that is precisely where negotiating capacity commitments or a national commercial arrangement becomes important.

I wouldn't redesign the entire operations system just yet. I would establish this capacity-and-commitment model first, because it will influence quotations, subscriptions, invoicing, inventory locations, utilization calculations, and the drag-and-drop asset movement interface we discussed earlier.

I suspect your unfinished thought was heading toward that same problem: *we are selling something we don't own or necessarily control.* That's workable as a business model, but only if Depot clearly distinguishes what CESCo can source from what CESCo can actually guarantee.

You said:

I think that your distinction really added some clarity here: We're selling custody, receiving, secure holding, inventory visibility, asset retrieval, and potentially dispatch. Storage is the physical substrate beneath those services. (Therefore, it is our responsibility to manage that substrate in such a way that it suits the customers needs and is obviously mutually beneficial) The customer doesn't need to manage where it is placed on in a unit or otherwise (that's what they are paying us for) The customer needs to know where it is, what condition it is in and when can it be to where it is needed and how quickly -and WE BETTER BE ABLE TO STAND AND DELIVER. So I think what our model should look like is a hub/spoke or hub/spoke hybrid. Initially, the former (everything ships to our office, and we deploy it to strategic stocking locations, record and report the details to our clients in their dashboard) the latter model as we grow (or some other one) might then be practical...

ChatGPT said:

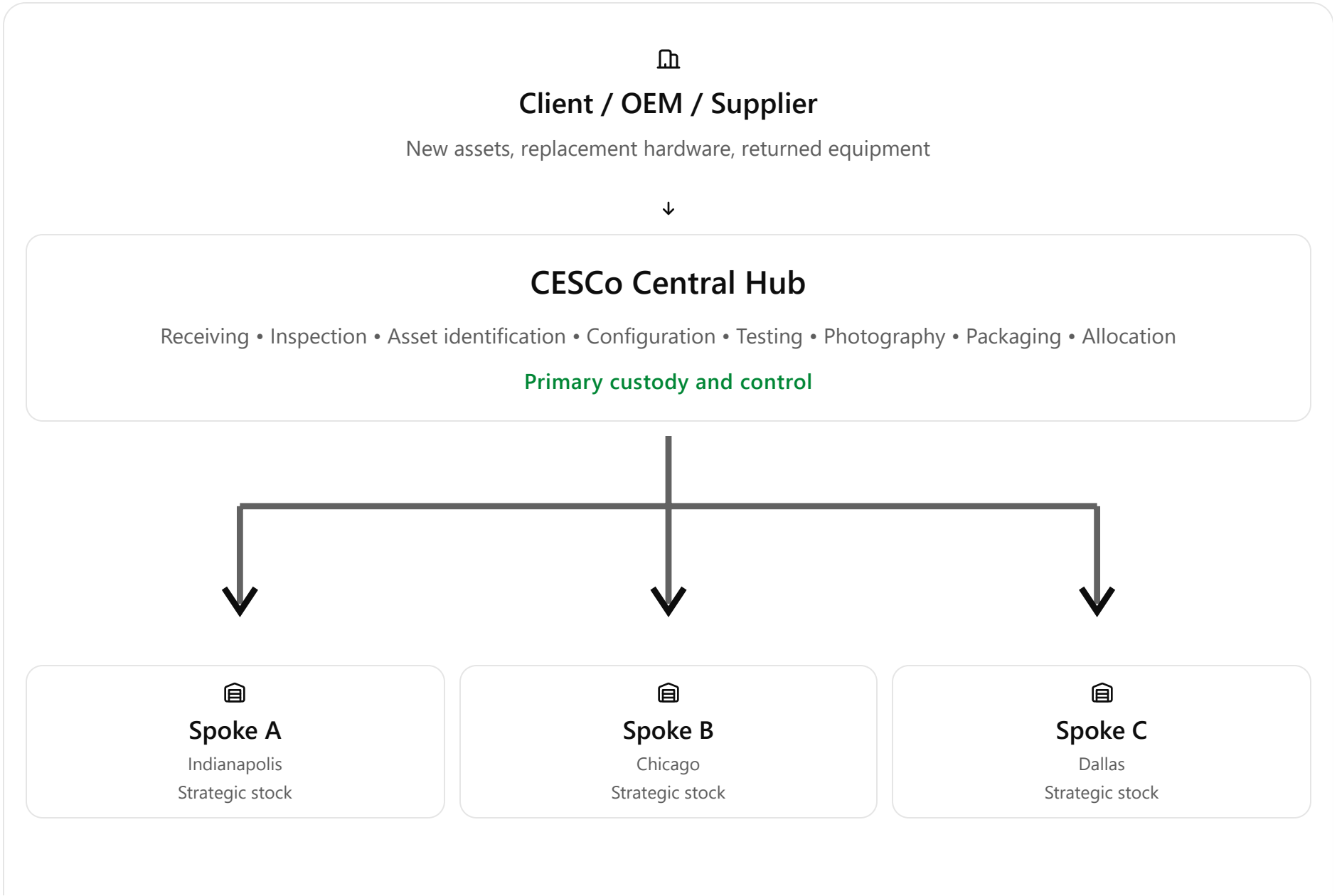
I think we've arrived at a much stronger definition of what CESCo Depot actually is. And it changes how I would approach the operations module.

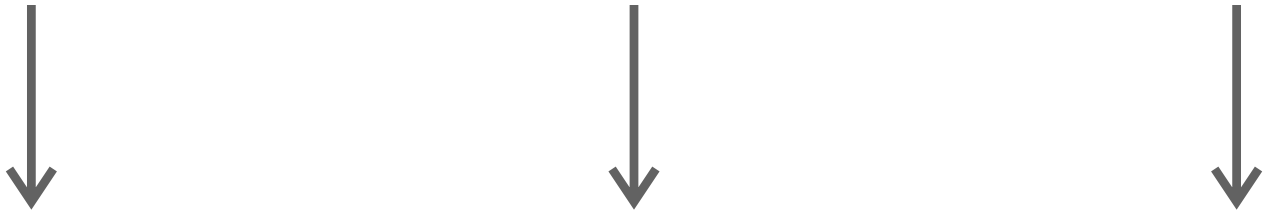
CESCo Depot is not a storage rental platform. It is a distributed asset custody, readiness, and fulfillment platform.

That distinction has commercial, operational, technical, and contractual consequences. Most importantly, it places responsibility for the physical infrastructure on CESCo while making asset visibility and dependable fulfillment the customer's experience.

Your proposed hub-and-spoke model fits that definition particularly well.

1. The initial CESCo Depot operating model





Field Technicians / Client Sites

Dispatch • Deployment • Failed-unit recovery • Return logistics

Illustrative network, not a representation of established CESCo facilities. Spokes could be leased units, dedicated facilities, or qualified partner locations.

Under this model, the central hub is where CESCo establishes what an asset is and whether it is ready for service. The spokes are where CESCo positions assets to meet demand.

That creates a consistent intake process regardless of the eventual storage provider.

There is one practical qualification: until CESCo has an appropriately equipped office or workshop, the initial hub will need to operate within the capacity of the facilities and resources actually available. Depot should support a single hub without assuming that it is already a full-scale warehouse.

2. The customer experience should reflect outcomes, not physical warehouse administration

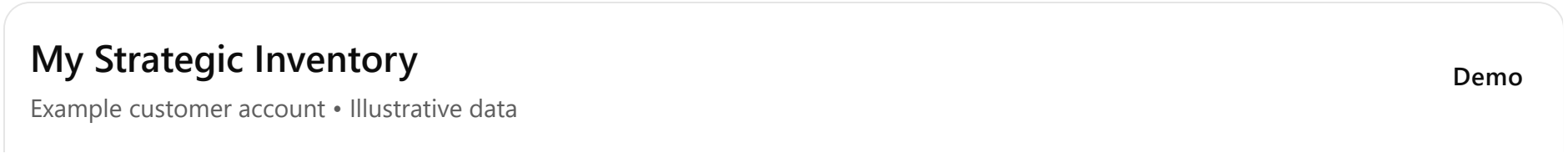
The customer should never need to understand the internal geography of a 10 × 20 storage unit.

They should be able to ask four questions and get trustworthy answers:

- **Where is my asset?** Its verified geographic location, custody holder, and current movement status.
- **What condition is it in?** Its physical condition, operational readiness, test results, configuration, and evidence.
- **Can I use it?** Whether it is available, reserved, in repair, in transit, quarantined, or otherwise unavailable.
- **When can it arrive?** The earliest supportable delivery or deployment window, based on location, access, shipping methods, technician availability, and service commitments.

The distinction between *physical condition* and *deployment readiness* is especially important. A perfectly functioning firewall sitting in storage is not necessarily deployment-ready if it lacks the client's required configuration.

3. An example of what the customer dashboard could become



Assets held	Deployable	Locations
24	21	3

Cisco Meraki MX68 — Ready

CES-1048 · Indianapolis, IN

Tested / configured — Location verified

Dell OptiPlex 7090 — Ready

CES-1052 · Chicago, IL

Inspected / tested — Location verified

Fortinet FortiGate 60F — Not ready

CES-1061 · Dallas, TX

Configuration pending — Location verified

Deployment availability

A delivery estimate becomes available when a destination, asset and fulfillment method are selected. Confirmed service commitments are distinguished from estimates.

We should not display "available within four hours" merely because a spare is in the same city as the customer. We must be able to account for actual retrieval time, courier availability, facility access, transit and any on-site work.

That is what makes your statement, "*we better be able to stand and deliver,*" an architectural requirement rather than simply a business aspiration.

4. Custody must be separate from location

This is probably the most important data-model decision emerging from our discussion.

An asset has a **location**, but it also has a **custodian**.

For example:

Event	Location	Custodian
Client ships firewall	Carrier network	Carrier
Delivered at central hub	Indianapolis	CESCo
Prepared for stocking	Indianapolis hub	CESCo
Shipped toward regional spoke	In transit	Carrier
Accepted by storage operator	Chicago facility	Storage partner

Verified into spoke inventory	Chicago facility	Authorized custodian
Released for deployment	In transit	Courier / technician
Delivered to client	Client site	Client or designated recipient

Each transition requires an event record. Ideally, that includes the initiating party, receiving party, timestamps, asset identifiers, condition evidence, and proof of custody transfer.

A package marked delivered by UPS does not automatically prove that the expected asset was received intact or added to verified inventory.

Depot needs to treat custody as an auditable chain of events, not simply a field containing the current address.

This is also closely aligned with the trust-continuity work we've been developing: a handoff is where the system needs to preserve evidence, or explicitly recognize uncertainty rather than quietly assume continuity.

5. The hub-and-spoke hybrid is a natural next stage

The initial model would be:

Phase I — Centralized intake, distributed stocking.

Everything enters through CESCo, is inspected and registered, then gets deployed into strategic spoke locations.

Eventually, we can add:

Phase II — Qualified direct-to-spoke intake.

A trusted OEM or supplier ships directly to a regional spoke that has suitable receiving and verification capabilities.

Phase III — Distributed processing.

Selected spokes gain the ability to inspect, test, configure, repackage, and dispatch equipment without routing it through Indianapolis.

The important architectural choice is to make *the hub a role, not a permanently hardcoded physical location*. A facility could have one or several capabilities: receiving, inspection, configuration, stocking, dispatch, and repair.

That way, the software supports the Phase I model from the beginning without requiring a major rewrite to introduce Phase II.

6. What I would change in Depot's development priorities

I would avoid building a complicated graphical warehouse floor plan yet. The drag-and-drop interface we discussed can eventually be valuable for CESCo administrators, but the underlying movements and custody records must work correctly first.

I would prioritize:

1. **Facility Registry:** Physical locations, operator agreements, capabilities, access rules, and active status.
2. **Asset Custody Ledger:** Append-only custody and condition events with evidence and audit trails.
3. **Inventory Allocation:** Assign assets to customers, geographic regions, and internal storage positions.
4. **Fulfillment Engine:** Evaluate whether and when a particular asset can be retrieved and delivered.
5. **Customer Asset Dashboard:** A clear view of asset condition, location, readiness and fulfillment status.

Commercial storage billing can then be designed around the services, assets, allocation requirements, and SLA obligations rather than simply reselling square footage.

For reliability, I'd also establish a minimum operating procedure for each spoke: authorized access, backup access arrangements, receiving cutoff times, retrieval authorization, shipping supplies, and escalation if an operator fails to perform. We shouldn't advertise an SLA that depends on a capability our storage partner has not committed to provide.

There is one further implication I find especially important.

CESCo Depot does not necessarily have to promise that a customer's assets will remain at a particular third-party facility. We need to promise that their assets will remain accounted for, appropriately protected, and available within the agreed service parameters.

That gives CESCo flexibility to manage its physical substrate: consolidate underutilized storage, expand capacity, change providers, or reposition assets closer to demand, while honoring any geographic, security, or relocation restrictions in the customer's agreement.

I think this is the operating concept worth formalizing before returning to the current operations assessment:

CESCo manages the facilities, custody, readiness, movement, and fulfillment. The customer manages business intent: which assets they want protected, where they need service coverage, and how quickly they need those assets delivered.

That is a more scalable and defensible business than selling customers space in somebody else's storage unit.